



InvestPuppy
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UNVARNISHED

Life after live

Serious when it matters.

About InvestPuppy

InvestPuppy builds Vektor, a systematic portfolio management platform for wealth management professionals.

What this series is

Every experienced practitioner thinks it. Almost nobody publishes it: *there has to be a better way.*

We thought it long enough that we went and built one.

Before that, we spent decades in the rooms.

The same project was failing for the third time. The project plan had been signed off before anyone had understood the first requirement.

The relationship was too warm for anyone to say so.

It isn't incompetence.

It's the incentive structure doing its job perfectly.

Nobody planned it this way. Nobody needed to.

We got frustrated enough to write it down. Then frustrated enough to build something. These papers are the writing-it-down part.

The something we built is a separate conversation.

The implementation did not.

Go-live is the end of the project. It says so in the project plan — the final milestone, the one the Gantt chart terminates at, the one the steering committee has been tracking for eleven months. It is not the end of anything. It is the beginning of a different, harder problem: the problem of an organisation built around a legacy system encountering, for the first time at production volume, the system that was supposed to replace it.

1. The Mythology of Go-Live

The go-live date functions as a destination. Everything before it is a journey. The kick-off is the departure. The UAT phase is the approach. Go-live is arrival. This mythology is maintained because it is useful: it gives the project a shape, gives the steering committee something to track, gives the vendor a milestone against which payment is triggered, and gives the project team a moment of completion.

The system went live.

What it does not give anyone is an accurate description of what actually happens on go-live day, or in the weeks that follow.

Go-live day is the first day the system is used in production, at volume, by the people who were not in the UAT environment, on the data that was not in the test dataset, for the transactions that were not in the test scripts. It is the first real test of the implementation. The eleven months that preceded it were, in various ways, a preparation for this test. The project plan treated it as the finish line. It is the starting gun.

2. The Hypercare Fiction

Most project plans include a hypercare phase — a period of intensified support immediately following go-live, typically two to four weeks. Hypercare ends when the project ends. The issues do not.

The issues that surface during hypercare are the obvious ones: configuration errors that appear under production load, data migration problems that emerge at volume, interface failures that the test environment did not replicate. These are resolved. The project team departs. Hypercare is logged as complete.

The issues that surface after hypercare are the real ones. The reporting that does not match the legacy system output the risk team was using as their source of truth. The workflow exception that occurs twice a month and was not in the test scripts. The user who has been processing transactions incorrectly for six weeks because the training did not cover the edge case they encounter daily. And — critically — the regulatory reporting failures that emerge when the first post-live reporting period closes and the output does not match what the compliance function was producing from the old system. These are not merely operational problems. They are reportable events. They arrive after

the project manager's engagement has ended.

3. The Workaround Economy

Every organisation that has been using a legacy financial system for more than five years has built a workaround economy around it. Spreadsheets that compensate for reporting limitations. Manual processes that handle transactions the system cannot. Institutional knowledge held by specific individuals who know which sequence of operations produces the output the system was not designed to produce directly.

The new system was not configured to accommodate these workarounds, because nobody documented them during discovery. They were not on the process maps. They were in the heads of the people who performed them.

The system that was built for the specification meets the organisation that has been using workarounds for eighteen months. Between them is a gap.

The gap is filled initially by people who know the old workarounds and have not yet learned the new ones. Then it is filled by new workarounds — built on top of the new system, invisible to the vendor, undocumented, dependent on the continued employment of the people who invented them.

The system went live. The implementation did not.

4. What Comes After Live

The post-live phase is not a support problem. It is an adoption problem, a change

management problem, a configuration problem, and a data quality problem — and it is substantially larger, in real terms, than most project plans acknowledge.

A post-live plan adequate to the actual challenge has five components:

One. A structured process for capturing and resolving configuration issues that only appear under production load — not a support ticket queue but a prioritised, resourced backlog with vendor involvement and defined resolution timelines.

Two. An adoption tracking mechanism that measures not go-live usage, but correct usage — the proportion of transactions being processed through the system in the way it was designed, rather than around it.

Three. A workaround audit conducted sixty days after go-live, identifying manual processes that have emerged around the system and the configuration changes that would eliminate them. This audit should be conducted by someone with access to the original specification — the gap between the specification and the workaround is the measure of the implementation's actual completeness.

Four. A regulatory reporting validation conducted at the close of the first full reporting period post-live, comparing system output against legacy output for every report with a regulatory or compliance dimension. Discrepancies are not post-live issues. They are pre-live failures that went undetected.

Five. A data quality review at ninety days, measuring mandate compliance, data completeness, and the accuracy of the migrated data against the source. Data quality problems that were present at migration but below the threshold of immediate visibility will surface here. They should be surfaced by design, not by a client complaint.

The project plan that ends at go-live is not a plan for the implementation. It is a plan for the project. These are not the same thing.

Plan for what comes after live.

It is longer than the project.